IN THE COURTS OF THE FOURTEENTH JUDICIAL CIRCUIT
Bay, Calhoun, Gulf, Holmes, Jackson, and Washington Counties
THE STATE OF FLORIDA

ADMINISTRATIVE ORDER #2026-00-04
(Rescinding Administrative Order #2025-00-10)

RE: ADMINISTRATIVE PLAN FOR THE FOURTEENTH JUDICIAL CIRCUIT JULY 1, 2026 – JANUARY 1, 2029

Whereas, pursuant to Article V, Section 2(d) of the Florida Constitution and section 43.26, Florida Statutes, the chief judge of each circuit is charged with the authority and power to promote the prompt and efficient administration of justice, and

Whereas, the Chief Judge, pursuant to Rule 2.215, Florida Rules of General Practice and Judicial Administration, has the responsibility to develop an administrative plan for the efficient and proper administration of all courts within the circuit, and

Whereas, the Chief Judge, through the plan, ensures the administrative organization of the circuit to affect the prompt disposition of cases and effective use of court resources,

NOW, THEREFORE, IT IS ORDERED AND ADJUDGED that the following Administrative Plan for the Fourteenth Judicial Circuit will be effective July 1, 2026 through January 1, 2029, unless amended or rescinded by further order of the court.

PURPOSE

Upon the effective date, this administrative plan rescinds the previous plan and adopts a plan that outlines the administration of the courts for the circuit as required by Rule 2.215, Florida Rules of Judicial Administration, and describes the organizational structure of the Fourteenth Judicial Circuit.

ROLE AND RESPONSIBILITY OF CHIEF JUDGE

The circuit, the Honorable Christopher N. Patterson, exercises administrative supervision over all courts within the Fourteenth Judicial Circuit and is empowered with judicial and administrative authority for the judges and officers of the Court of the Fourteenth Judicial Circuit. The Chief Judge is responsible to the Chief Justice of the Supreme Court of Florida.

The duties of the Chief Judge as outlined by Florida Statutes 43.26 include:

- To assign judges to any division of the court and to determine the length of the assignment.
- To regulate the use of the courtrooms and supervise dockets and calendars.
- To require attendance of state attorneys, public defenders, clerks, bailiffs, and all other officers of the court.
- To do everything necessary to promote the prompt and efficient administration of justice in the courts over which he is chief judge.
- To delegate to the trial court administrator, by administrative order, the authority to bind the circuit in contract; and
- To manage, operate, and oversee the jury system as provided in section 40.001, Florida Statutes.

The Chief Judge oversees court administration as outlined in Rule 2.215, Florida Rules of General Practice and Judicial Administration, and shall ensure an appropriate and sound organizational structure for the Fourteenth Judicial Circuit. In this capacity, the Chief Judge shall directly supervise the Trial Court Administrator.

In support of the administrative responsibility, the Chief Judge shall sign all Fourteenth Judicial Circuit Administrative Orders that effect the administration of the circuit. All Administrative Orders shall be filed with the Trial Court Administrator who will record each order with the appropriate Clerk of Court.

The Chief Judge shall serve as a member of the First District Court of Appeals Senior Judge Review Board.

ADMINISTRATIVE ASSIGNMENTS

The Chief Judge may appoint administrative judges to ensure the efficient and effective management of the circuit's various divisions and courts. These appointments and specific duties are as follows:

1. **Judge Brantley S. Clark, Jr. – *Acting Chief Judge***
   Acting Chief Judge: Judge Brantley S. Clark, Jr., shall serve as Acting Chief Judge when Chief Judge is absent from the circuit.

2. **Judge Elijah Smiley – *Administrative Probate/Guardianship Judge***
   Duties include ***circuit wide*** general administrative oversight of Probate/Guardianship divisions and courts, and guardianship court programs.
   a. Monitoring probate and guardianship case time standards for compliance with R.2.250 and 2.545.

3. **Judge Brantley S. Clark, Jr. – *Administrative Juvenile Judge***
   Duties include ***circuit wide*** general administrative oversight of juvenile divisions and courts, and juvenile court programs, including:
   a. Monitoring juvenile case time standards for compliance with R.2.250 and 2.545.
   b. Oversight of teen court.

4. **Judge Ana Maria Garcia – *Administrative Criminal Judge for Calhoun, Gulf, Holmes, Jackson, and Washington Counties***
   Duties include general administrative oversight of criminal divisions and courts, and criminal court programs including:
   a. Monitoring criminal case time standards for compliance with R.2.250 and 2.545.
   b. Monitoring juror time management for compliance with R.2.256.
   c. Examining the status of inmates in the county jail for compliance with R.2.215(b)8.
   d. Ensuring that Grand Juries are empaneled in compliance with Administrative Order #2014-00-01 and applicable law.
   e. Monitor pending post-conviction or collateral relief cases for compliance with R.2.215(b)7.

5. **Judge Dustin Stephenson – *Administrative Criminal Law Judge for Bay County***
   Duties include general administrative oversight of criminal divisions and courts, and criminal court programs including:
   a. Monitoring criminal case time standards for compliance with R.2.250 and 2.545.
   b. Monitoring juror time management for compliance with R.2.256.
   c. Examining the status of inmates in the county jail for compliance with R.2.215(b)8.
   d. Empaneling the Grand jury in Bay County in compliance with Administrative Order #2014-00-01 and applicable law.
   e. Monitor pending post-conviction cases for compliance with R.2.215(b)7.

6. **Judge James J. Goodman – *Administrative Civil Law Judge***
   Duties include ***circuit wide*** general administrative oversight of civil divisions and courts, and civil court programs including:
   a. Monitoring civil case time standards for compliance with R.2.250., 2.215(f), and 2.545.

7. **Judge Russell S. Roberts – *Administrative Family Law Judge***
   Duties include ***circuit wide*** general administrative oversight of family divisions and courts, and family court programs including:
   a. Monitoring family case time standards for compliance with R.2.250 and 2.215(f), and 2.545.
   b. Ensuring family law division operates as provided by R.12.000, et al.
   c. Monitoring family court programs.
   d. Supervising Judge of magistrates and child support hearing officers.

8. **Judge E. William Dyer - *Administrative County Court Judge for Bay County***
   Duties include general administrative oversight of Bay County Court, and county court programs including:
   a. Monitoring criminal case time standards for compliance with R.2.250, 2.215(f) and 2.545.
   b. Monitoring juror time management for compliance with R.2.256.
   c. Examining the status of inmates in the county jail for compliance with R.2.215(b)8.
   d. Monitoring county court programs.

9. **Judge Colby Peel – *Administrative County Court Judge for Calhoun, Gulf, Holmes, Jackson, and Washington Counties***
   Duties include general administrative oversight of County Court for Calhoun, Gulf, Holmes, Jackson, and Washington Counties, and county court programs including:
   a. Monitoring criminal case time standards for compliance with R.2.250, 2.215(f) and 2.545.
   b. Monitoring juror time management for compliance with R.2.256.
   c. Examining the status of inmates in the county jail for compliance with R.2.215(b)8.
   d. Monitoring county court programs.

COURT COMMITTEES AND RELATED APPOINTMENTS

The following committees are created to help ensure the efficient and proper administration of the court and to receive circuit-wide input. Each court committee chairperson should report to the chief judge for directions or guidance relative to the area that their committee oversees. These committees and appointments are as follows:

1. **Court Technology Advisory Committee** – The Chief Judge, the Trial Court Technology Officer, the Trial Court Administrator, Judge Colby Peel, Judge Ana Garcia, Judge William S. Henry, Judge Timothy C. Campbell, and Circuit General Counsel. **Task:** Review and recommend technology changes having circuit wide impact.

2. **Fourteenth Judicial Circuit Bench/Bar & Professionalism Committee** – The Chief Judge, Judge William S. Henry, Judge Russell S. Roberts, Judge Brandon J. Young, Judge Devin D. Collier, and Judge Alicia Carothers. **Tasks:** To provide a mechanism for communication and dialogue between the bar and the bench; to enhance professionalism; and to comply with SC13-688.

3. **Bay County Law Library Committee –** Judge Shonna Gay and Judge E. William Dyer shall serve as judicial members on the Bay County Law Library Board.

4. **Personnel Advisory Committee** – The Chief Judge as chair, the Trial Court Administrator, the Supervising Administrative Judge, and the relevant staff manager, or other committees and individuals as designated by the chief judge. **Task:** Review and recommend to the chief judge candidates to fill vacant positions, except the Trial Court Administrator and judicial assistants.

5. **Fourteenth Judicial Circuit Pro Bono Committee Judicial Representative** – Judge Brandon J. Young.

6. **Fourteenth Circuit Judge Mentors –** The Chief Judge shall serve as mentor coordinator for this program, pursuant to R. 2.320. The following are certified mentor judges: Judge Brantley S. Clark, Jr., Judge Colby Peel, and Judge Ana Garica, Judge Dustin Stepehnson, Judge Will Dyer.

ROLE AND RESPONSIBILITY OF THE TRIAL COURT ADMINISTRATOR

The Trial Court Administrator of the Circuit exercises administrative supervision over designated court programs for and on behalf of the Fourteenth Judicial Circuit. The Trial Court Administrator provides direct supervision to court administration state and county funded court employees assigned to the circuit on behalf of the judges. Also, the Trial Court Administrator develops the circuit's budget requests for each of the counties and the state; coordinates the circuit's response to American with Disabilities Act requests; and oversees other functions related to the executive and administrative governance of the trial court system. The Trial Court Administrator reports directly to the Chief Judge of the Circuit.

AMENDMENTS TO THE ADMINSTRATIVE PLAN

Amendments, deletions, or additions to this administrative plan shall be made as needed.

DONE AND ORDERED in Chambers, at Panama City, Bay County, this 8th day of June, 2026.

CHRISTOPHER N. PATTERSON
CHIEF JUDGE